



GETTY IMAGES

SOUND BARRIER

It's symphony of chainsaws, it's the assault of a million bees, it's the sound that would have frozen Superman mid-flight. Already soccer's supermen are reeling on the ground. The Vuvuzela, South Africa's traditional football trumpet, has provided the original soundtrack to the first African World Cup. When played perfectly, the instrument can hit 127 decibels, louder than the Brazilian samba drum, just under the 130 decibels produced by an airline jet taking off.

The Vuvuzela's constant echo in South Africa has delighted fans but the global football community is not amused. Portugal's Cristiano Ronaldo said, "A lot of players don't like them, but they are going to have to get used to them." His

AP Photo



equally stellar rival Lionel Messi said, "It is impossible to communicate. It is like being deaf." England's defender Jamie Carragher didn't miss a chance to let out a little personal trumpet as he refused to be silenced by the Vuvuzela. "I make more noise than any African football horn," he says.

The complaints are most strong from the TV lobby. Producers can either let in 'crowd sound' during a broadcast, making their commentators compete with the Vuvus, minus Carragher's help. Or they can block out the crowd noise, but then only the commentators are heard. So a TV solution: ban the noisy buzzers. The FIFA won't play ball there. So the moaning continues.